

The Mountain That Rumbled

A story about volcanoes, lava, and sleeping mountains





Isla and Theo stood in front of a giant volcano model at the science museum.

The mountain looked quiet at first.

Then it gave a low rumble.

Theo jumped. ‘Did it just growl?’

Isla stared at the glowing top. ‘I think this mountain has something to say.’

Just then, Ms. Alvarez walked over smiling.

‘You’ve found one of Earth’s most powerful wonders,’ she said. ‘A volcano.’



Theo pointed at the red glow near the top. ‘Is that fire?’

‘Not exactly,’ said Ms. Alvarez. ‘Deep underground, rock can get so hot that it melts. That melted rock underground is called magma.’

‘And when it comes out?’ Isla asked.

‘Then it is called lava,’ said Ms. Alvarez.



Right on cue, the volcano model bubbled and a bright red stream slid down the side.

‘Lava!’ Theo said.

Ms. Alvarez nodded. ‘Volcanoes can also send out ash, steam, and gases.’

Isla looked curious. ‘Do all volcanoes erupt all the time?’

‘No,’ said Ms. Alvarez. ‘Some volcanoes are active. That means they are erupting now, have erupted recently, or may erupt again.’



‘Can you give examples?’ Theo asked.

‘Of course,’ said Ms. Alvarez. ‘Kīlauea in Hawaii is an active volcano. Mount Etna in Italy is active too. And Stromboli, also in Italy, is famous for frequent eruptions.’

Isla looked back at the model. ‘So active volcanoes are awake.’

Ms. Alvarez smiled. ‘That’s a great way to think about it.’



‘What about volcanoes that are quiet?’ Isla asked.

‘Those are sometimes dormant volcanoes,’ said Ms. Alvarez. ‘Dormant means they are resting right now, but they could erupt again someday.’

Theo thought for a moment. ‘So dormant means sleeping?’

‘Exactly,’ said Ms. Alvarez. ‘Mount Fuji in Japan, Mount Rainier in the United States, and Mauna Kea in Hawaii are good examples.’



The volcano model rumbled one more time.

This time, neither kid stepped back.

Instead, Theo smiled. 'It's like Earth has secret mountains with hot energy inside.'

'And some are awake,' Isla added, 'while some are just napping.'

At the end of the trip, Isla wrote in her notebook:

'A volcano is a mountain with a story from deep inside Earth.'



What the Kids Learned

- A volcano is an opening in Earth's crust.
- Magma is melted rock underground.
- Lava is magma that reaches the surface.
- Active volcanoes are erupting now or may erupt again soon.
- Dormant volcanoes are quiet for now but may erupt in the future.